

“We are certain that our model is applicable to any institute”

J A Bhavsar was lucky that the senior management at Institute for Technology and Management (ITM) was pro-open source. Even then, he had to face a number of other challenges while setting up a FOSS-based IT infrastructure at the institute. Successfully overcoming these obstacles and, hence, paving the way for other educational institutes to confidently adopt ITM's open source model, makes him our Tux Hero.

*W*hile working on this story about ITM's IT infrastructure, I realised that the face behind the open source implementation was J A Bhavsar, group head (IT), ITM Business School, Mumbai. So when did he first get acquainted with GNU/Linux? “I came across Linux in 1999 when I noticed a Linux installation on my friend's computer,” he says. That seemed to sow the seeds of freedom in his mind. Some time later, when ITM was considering the deployment of GNU/Linux and other free software solutions at the institute, Bhavsar was ready to take the plunge.

“While the initiative was taken by the chairman, I guided the implementation with the help of a Mumbai consultancy, The Argon Company, which is very familiar with Linux. One of the consultants was Rishi Ganguly, a close friend of Nitin Putcha (the chairman's son). Ganguly, who currently works for Apple, is an avid Linux enthusiast. He knew Richard Stallman, whom he invited for a talk at TIFR in Chembur, Mumbai, on January 21, 2004. I attended this talk.”

Now, the institute has become a role model for others. Bhavsar is also vocal about the institute's willingness to invite outsiders to get trained on the technologies at the ITM campus. This is the best way you can ‘pay it forward’ in the FOSS world.

But it was not like he only had to take over an existing GNU/Linux deployment. The FRESSO stack had to be built from the ground up. He confides, “My group and a two-member team from The Argon Company started from scratch.”

Unlike other organisations where business heads are basically a bit wary of GNU/Linux, at ITM, Bhavsar confided that, “...both our chairman, Dr

P.V. Ramana, and his son, Nitin Putcha, were pro Linux.” This was one of those rare cases where the IT head did not need to convince the management with respect to the deployment of open source.

J A Bhavsar, group head (IT),
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